

Michael Lewrick, Patrick Link & Larry Leifer

The Design Thinking Playbook & Toolbox

Lewrick (author/strategist) · Link (HSLU) · Leifer (Stanford, d.school co-founder)



"Design thinking is a mindset, not just a process."

"The right tool at the right moment turns a workshop into progress."

1 WHY THIS THINKER MATTERS

When you need the actual tool — the empathy map, the trend radar, the critical-items diagram — this trio wrote the reference. Their Playbook and Toolbox are the operational backbone of Units 5, 6 and 10 in this course.

2 INTELLECTUAL FOUNDATION

Michael Lewrick is an innovation strategist and author; Patrick Link is a professor of product innovation at Lucerne (HSLU); Larry Leifer is a Stanford design professor and co-founder of the d.school and the ME310 project course. Together they compiled the field's most-used practical toolkits.

3 FRAMEWORKS · TOOLS · MODELS

NAME	WHAT IT IS
The Design Thinking Toolbox	A curated set of ~50 hands-on DT methods
The Design Thinking Playbook	Mindshifts for applying DT in business
Persona & empathy tools	Templates for user understanding
Trend & context tools	Trend radar, context mapping, vision cone
Critical-items & success tools	Assumption triage and success definition

4 HOW IT'S OPERATIONALIZED

- Select the right tool for each phase from the Toolbox
- Use mindshifts to move teams from analysis to action
- Template empathy, definition and testing consistently
- Combine foresight tools with user research
- Prioritise assumptions before prototyping

5 LIMITATIONS & CRITIQUES

- Compendium breadth over theoretical depth
- Tools can be applied mechanically without insight
- Quality depends on the team, not the template
- Little independent effectiveness evidence per tool
- Risk of tool overload without judgement

6 ENDURING IMPACT

- The most widely used practical DT toolkits in teaching
- Standard reference in design-thinking courses
- Leifer's ME310 shaped global design pedagogy
- Made a large method set accessible to non-designers
- Direct anchor for BCOBM126 Units 5, 6 and 10 tools

SELECTED WORKS

THE DESIGN THINKING TOOLBOX <i>A Guide to Mastering the Most Popular Tools</i> LEWRICK ET AL. · 2020	THE DESIGN THINKING PLAYBOOK <i>Mindful Digital Transformation</i> LEWRICK ET AL. · 2018	THE DESIGN THINKING LIFE PLAYBOOK <i>Empower Yourself</i> LEWRICK ET AL. · 2020	ME310 PROJECT PEDAGOGY <i>Stanford (Leifer)</i> LEIFER · ongoing
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REFERENCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

- Lewrick, M., Link, P. and Leifer, L. (2020) *The Design Thinking Toolbox*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.
- Lewrick, M., Link, P. and Leifer, L. (2018) *The Design Thinking Playbook*. Hoboken, NJ: Wiley.